

A source-document review of the understanding of religion and Islam in the official history books taught in high schools between 1931 and 1941

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Abstract. [Tarih I](#) and [Tarih II](#) are not merely textbooks recounting the past; they are official state publications that also set out a particular worldview concerning the origin of religion and of Islam. This review assesses 34 direct quotations from the books together with 22 verses of the Qur'an, and arrives at 19 separate findings. **The findings show that the books foreground a religion of human origin in place of religion sent down by God, human reflection in place of revelation, the founding of a religion in place of prophethood, and nature-centred explanations in place of creation.** The central claim of this review is that the divergence between this official historical narrative — taught in lycées for eleven years — and the Qur'an lies not in detail but **at the level of the articles of belief.**

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Scope: The study rests on the section "Beşer Tarihine Giriş" (Introduction to Human History) of *Tarih I*, printed pp. 1–24, and the section "İslâm Tarihi" (History of Islam) of *Tarih II*, printed pp. 79–93.

1. The official standing of the source

The books are not a private author's opinion. *Tarih I* [1] and *Tarih II* [2] were written by the Turkish History Research Society and printed at the **State Press** (Istanbul) for the **Ministry of Education**. The table below gives every date, figure and reference that could be established.

Date	Event	Source
1931	First printing orders for <i>Tarih I</i> (30,000 copies) and <i>Tarih II</i> (25,000 copies)	[3] [4] [5]
1932	Board decisions (27, 213, 239), revision and correction of vols. I and II	[6]
1933	Second edition · separate series for middle schools: <i>Ortamektep için Tarih</i>	[9] [10]
1941	<i>Tarih I</i> reprinted; third printing order for <i>Tarih II</i> (3,000 copies)	[7] [11]
1942	Board decision 222: lycée years 1, 2, 3; 364: middle-school history books	[8]

The same thirteen people prepared both volumes: the society's president, who was **Secretary-General of the Presidency**, nine **deputies** in parliament, two **colonels**, and one history **teacher** at the Music Teachers' School. The books were **written for the lycées** and distributed to middle schools and lycées alike. These three facts together — a ministerial order, an authorship board drawn from the executive and the legislature, and eleven years of compulsory use — are sufficient for the books to count as *the state's official teaching*.

2. The axes examined

The comparison was carried out along five axes; the table below gives the pages each axis rests on and the index range of the quotations and findings in it.

No	Axis	Source	Quotations	Findings
1	The origin and nature of religion	<i>Tarih I</i> , pp. 2, 21-24	Quote-01– Quote-10	Finding-01– Finding-05
2	Creation and the origin of man	<i>Tarih I</i> , pp. 2-7	Quote-11– Quote-18	Finding-06– Finding-08
3	Revelation, prophethood and the source of the Qur'an	<i>Tarih II</i> , pp. 89-93	Quote-19– Quote-25	Finding-09– Finding-12
4	The origin of belief in jinn and angels	<i>Tarih II</i> , p. 91	Quote-26– Quote-28	Finding-13– Finding-14
5	Scripture, law and sacred place	<i>Tarih II</i> , pp. 84-86, 92	Quote-29– Quote-32	Finding-15– Finding-17

3. The comparison, axis by axis

3.1 The origin and nature of religion

Each finding is given together with the quotation and the verse it rests on.

The birth of religion is tied to a wholly human chain

[Quote-01] "Ata korkusu yavaş yavaş anlaşılmaz bir surette 'kabile allahı' korkusuna intikal etti. ... Bu suretle Allah mefhumunun başlangıç hali olan 'ulvileştirilmiş ata' ya, temsili olarak, muhtelif hayvanlara ait şekiller verildi." — **Tarih I, p. 21** [Fear of the ancestor passed imperceptibly into fear of a "tribal god". ... Thus the "exalted ancestor", which is the initial form of the concept of God, was given representational shapes drawn from various animals.]

[Quote-02] "Bu kurbanları kesecek diğer pak tanınmış bir sınıf meydana çıktı: ilk rahipler sınıfı. ... Bütün bu müşterek âdetler ve inanışlar insanların aralarında zihni ve hissi birtakım bağlar kurdu ve insanlarda müşterek düşünce ve müşterek harekete saik oldu." — **Tarih I, p. 23** [Another class, held to be pure, emerged to slaughter these sacrifices: the first class of priests. ... All these shared customs and beliefs created intellectual and emotional bonds among people and moved them to common thought and common action.]

[Quote-03] "İşte bu hâdiseye biz bugün din namını veriyoruz." — **Tarih I, p. 23** [It is this phenomenon that we today call religion.]

[Verse-01] "He has ordained for you the religion He enjoined upon Noah, and that which We have revealed to you, and that which We enjoined upon Abraham, Moses and Jesus: that you uphold the religion and do not be divided in it." — **Ash-Shūrā 13**

[Verse-02] "We sent no messenger before you without revealing to him: 'There is no god but I, so worship Me.'" — **Al-Anbiyā' 25**

[Finding-01] The books tie the birth of religion to a wholly human chain: fear, the ancestor cult, the tribal god, shared customs, a priestly class and finally the concept of unity. In the Qur'an, by contrast, religion is not the outcome of an evolution but the single principle God enjoined on every prophet from Noah to Jesus.

Religion is an institution brought into being by human beings

[Quote-04] "Görülüyor ki insanlar cemaat halinde yaşamaya başladıktan sora, diğer içtimaî müesseseler gibi din müessesesini de vücuda getirmişlerdir." — **Tarih I, p. 24** [It is evident that once people began to live in community they brought the institution of religion into being, just as they did the other social institutions.]

[Verse-03] "Truly, the religion in the sight of God is Islam." — **Āl 'Imrān 19**

[Finding-02] Religion is counted an institution founded by human beings, like the other social institutions. In

the Qur'an the giver of religion is God. The two accounts of origin cannot be reconciled.

Divinity is a concept found by human intelligence

[Quote-05] "Ülûhiyet mefhumunu bulan, bu mefhumun sırlarını keşfeden ve bugün dahi keşfetmiye devam eden, insan zekâsıdır." — **Tarih I, p. 24** [It is human intelligence that found the concept of divinity, that discovered its secrets, and that continues to discover them today.]

[Quote-06] "İnsanların korku ve zâf hisleri, dimağın son ve çok yeni ilmî keşiflerle nurlanması sayesinde gittikçe azaldı. Ve insanlar hakikati bundan sora daha bariz görmeye başladılar." — **Tarih I, p. 24** [People's feelings of fear and weakness gradually diminished as the mind was illuminated by the latest and most recent scientific discoveries. And thereafter people began to see the truth more clearly.]

[Quote-07] "İnsan, benliğindeki kuvveti ve ferdi olduğu cemaatin içtimaî kudretini takdire muvaffak olmiya başladı. Artık onun için her türlü tekâmül, huzur ve emniyet membaı, cemiyettir." — **Tarih I, p. 24** [Man began to appreciate the strength within himself and the social power of the community of which he is a member. Henceforth, for him, the source of all progress, peace and security is society.]

[Verse-04] "Vision does not grasp Him, but He grasps all vision." — **Al-An'âm 103**

[Finding-03] Divinity is treated as a concept waiting to be discovered, and what found it is human intelligence; the fear and weakness on which religious conception rests are described as passing states that diminish as science advances. In the Qur'an God is not a concept encompassed by human perception but the real being who encompasses perception. An explanation that makes divinity a human construct is, in doctrinal terms, **a denial of divinity**. The books put society in the place thus vacated: the source of peace and security is now society.

The whole of the unseen is declared "fabrication"

[Quote-08] "...tabiatın fevkinde ve haricindeki bütün mefhumların, insan dimağı için kendi tarafından uydurma şeylerden başka bir şey olmayacağı meydana çıkar." — **Tarih I, p. 2** [it becomes clear that all concepts above and outside nature can be nothing, for the human mind, other than things fabricated by itself.]

[Verse-05] "who believe in the unseen and keep up the prayer" — **Al-Baqara 3**

[Finding-04] Every concept above and outside nature is declared, for the human mind, a "fabrication". This principle covers not one article of belief but the whole of the unseen; faith in the unseen cannot be built upon it. Yet belief in the unseen is the first quality the Qur'an names when it describes the believers.

Primitive man has no religion; unity comes later

[Quote-09] "İptidaî insanda Allah ve din hakkında hiçbir fikir ve kanaat yoktu." — **Tarih I, p. 23-24** [Primitive man had no idea or conviction whatever concerning God and religion.]

[Quote-10] "Din fikri, insanlar cemiyet hayatına sarahaten atıldığı nispette genişlemeye başlar, vahdet mefhumuna yaklaşır ve nihayet, tabiatın kudret ve azametile daha ziyade anlaşılması kabil, hakikî bir mahiyet alır." — **Tarih I, p. 24** [The idea of religion begins to widen in proportion as people enter clearly into social life, approaches the concept of unity, and at last takes on a real character, more capable of being understood through the power and majesty of nature.]

[Verse-06] "So set your face towards the religion, turning to Him: the natural disposition upon which God has made mankind. There is no changing God's creation." — **Ar-Rûm 30**

[Finding-05] According to the books, primitive man had no idea whatever of God or religion; the concept of unity, which resembles tawhid, is not the beginning but a late stage of evolution. The Qur'an states that man is created upon a natural disposition. The books reverse the order.

3.2 Creation and the origin of man

The emergence of life is explained without any agent outside nature

[Quote-11] "Her halde, hayatın, herhangi bir tabiat harici amilin müdahalesi olmaksızın dünya üzerinde tabî, zarurî bir kimya ve fizik seyri neticesi olduğunu kabul etmek lâzımdır." — **Tarih I, p. 5** [In any case, it must be accepted that life is the result of a natural, necessary chemical and physical course upon the earth, without the intervention of any agent outside nature.]

[Quote-12] "Fakat hayatın, dünya üzerinde nasıl başladığını henüz kat'î surette bilmiyoruz." — **Tarih I, p. 5** [But we do not yet know with certainty how life began upon the earth.]

[Verse-07] "Indeed, We created everything by measure." — **Al-Qamar 49**

[Finding-06] The statement is not descriptive but **normative**: "it must be accepted". On the same page the books openly concede the limit of their own knowledge; yet they do not apply that caution to the negative verdict — a matter admitted to be unknown is settled by excluding any agent outside nature from the outset. The Qur'an, by contrast, ties creation not to chance but to intent and measure.

Man is counted a creature of nature

[Quote-13] "Filhakika, insan, tabiatın mahlûkudur." — **Tarih I, p. 2** [Indeed, man is a creature of nature.]

[Quote-14] "İnsanların, tabî mahlûk olarak dünyada zuhûr ettiklerini gördük." — **Tarih I, p. 7** [We have seen that human beings appeared on earth as natural creatures.]

[Verse-08] "The likeness of Jesus in God's sight is that of Adam: He created him from dust, then said to him 'Be' — and he was." — **Âl 'Imrân 59**

[Finding-07] In the books nature is presented as the creator of man: what is taught is that man is the created and nature the creator. In the Qur'an the creator of man is God. The agent of the act has been changed.

Man is placed at the end of the animal chain

[Quote-15] "Hulâsa insanlar, sularda kaynaşıp çırpınan bir mevcuttan, çok yavaş yürüyen bir tekâmülle, bugünkü şekle geldiler." — **Tarih I, p. 5** [In sum, human beings came to their present form, through a very slowly advancing evolution, from a being that teemed and floundered in the waters.]

[Quote-16] "Bu hayvan zümresinin başında: sıra ile maymunlar, kuyruksuz maymunlar ve nihayet insanlar bulunmaktadır." — **Tarih I, p. 4** [At the head of this class of animals are, in order: monkeys, apes, and finally human beings.]

[Quote-17] "Gördük ki, hayat zincirinin son halkası insandır. Bu zincire nazaran insanın sair memeli hayvanlar gibi, daha basit bir sınıfa ait cetlerden geldiği kanaatine varılır." — **Tarih I, p. 5** [We have seen that the last link in the chain of life is man. According to this chain one arrives at the conviction that man, like other mammals, descends from ancestors belonging to a simpler class.]

[Quote-18] "Filhakika umumiyetle iddia olunuyor ki, insanın ve büyük maymunların ... müşterek bir cetleri vardır." — **Tarih I, p. 5** [Indeed it is generally asserted that man and the great apes ... have a common ancestor.]

[Verse-09] "Be mindful of your Lord, who created you from a single soul, and from it created its mate, and from the two of them spread countless men and women." — **An-Nisâ' 1**

[Finding-08] The books set out the conviction that man came about from simple living things through a long process of evolution, and creation is explained as a nature-centred process. The Qur'an traces the beginning of mankind to a single soul and states that the human race issued from that first creation. The disagreement should therefore not be reduced to the question "did man descend from apes?". The real division lies in whether divine knowledge, power and will — or transformative processes operating within nature — is accepted as the fundamental explanation of the creation of man and of living things.

3.3 Revelation, prophethood and the source of the Qur'an

This is the densest axis of the report.

The divine source of revelation is not affirmed in the books' own voice

[**Quote-19**] "Muhammedin koyduğu esasların toplu olduğu kitaba Kuran denir. ... **İslâm an'anesinde** bu ayetlerin Muhammede Cebrail adında bir melek vasıtasile Allah tarafından vahiy, yani ilham edildiği **kabul olunur.**" — **Tarih II, p. 90** [The book in which the principles laid down by Muhammad are gathered is called the Qur'an. ... In Islamic tradition it is accepted that these verses were revealed — that is, inspired — to Muhammad by God through an angel named Gabriel.]

[**Verse-10**] "Nor does he speak from his own desire. It is nothing but a revelation revealed to him." — **An-Najm 3-4**

[**Finding-09**] The divine source of revelation is given not as the books' own verdict but referred to a third party, with the qualification "in Islamic tradition ... it is accepted". The divine source belongs to tradition, the human explanation to the books themselves. The Qur'an, by contrast, states revelation not as a report of tradition but in its own voice, as a definitive judgement.

Revelation is counted the product of a long reflection

[**Quote-20**] "**Tarihî noktai nazardan** da mütalea edildiği zaman görülüyor ki: Muhammet birdenbire Allahın Resulüyüm diyerek ortaya çıkmamıştır. O, ... yıllarca tefekkürden sora **kendisinde vahiy ve ilham fikri doğmuştur.**" — **Tarih II, p. 90** [Considered also from the historical point of view, it is seen that Muhammad did not appear suddenly declaring "I am the Messenger of God". He ... after years of reflection, the idea of revelation and inspiration was born in him.]

[**Quote-21**] "Muhammet 40 yaşına geldiği zaman vatandaşlarını, **kendinin bulduğu** ve doğru olduğuna inandığı yeni bir dine davete başladı." — **Tarih II, p. 89** [When Muhammad reached the age of forty he began to invite his countrymen to a new religion which he had found himself and believed to be true.]

[**Quote-22**] "Muhammet **uzun bir devirdeki tefekkürlerin mahsulü olan ayetleri** lüzum ve ihtiyaçlara göre takrir ediyordu." — **Tarih II, p. 91** [Muhammad set forth, according to need and circumstance, the verses that were the product of the reflections of a long period.]

[**Verse-11**] "Indeed, he reflected and deliberated. May he perish, how he deliberated! Again, may he perish, how he deliberated! Then he looked. Then he frowned and scowled. Then he turned away and grew arrogant. And he said: 'This is nothing but magic handed down. **This is nothing but the word of a human being.**' I shall cast him into Saqar. And what can make you know what Saqar is? It spares nothing and leaves nothing; it scorches the skin of man." — **Al-Muddaththir 18-29**

[**Finding-10**] According to the books the idea of revelation arose in Muhammad after years of reflection, the religion is one he found himself, and the verses are the product of the reflections of a long period. The Qur'an, for its part, names the characterisation "the word of a human being" and attaches to it the gravest consequence, and it records that the characterisation was itself the outcome of deliberation — "he reflected and deliberated". The verdict of the books is that very expression which the Qur'an rejects; that it was long deliberated does not justify it.

The Prophet is counted a founder and the definition of messengership is declared an error

[**Quote-23**] "Vaizlikten Nebiliğe, Nebilikten nihayet Allahın Resulü haline geçti. ... sonunda cihanşümul bir dinin **müessisi** oldu." — **Tarih II, p. 91** [He passed from preacher to prophet, and from prophet at last to Messenger of God. ... in the end he became the founder of a universal religion.]

[**Quote-24**] "Aksi takdirde Muhammedi, **her şeyi bir melekten alan ve aynen muhitine tebliğ eden** ümmî, cahil, hissiz hareketsiz bir put derekesine indirmek **hatasından** kurtulmak mümkün olmaz." — **Tarih II, p. 93** [Otherwise it is not possible to escape the error of reducing Muhammad to the level of an illiterate, ignorant, unfeeling and motionless idol who takes everything from an angel and conveys it to his surroundings exactly as received.]

[**Verse-12**] "O Messenger! Convey what has been sent down to you from your Lord. If you do not, you will not

have delivered His message." — **Al-Mā'ida 67**

[Verse-13] "...those who follow the Messenger, the unlettered prophet, whom they find written in their own Torah and Gospel..." — **Al-A'raf 157**

[Finding-11] The Prophet is described as the founder of the religion; moreover the definition of messengership itself — receiving everything from an angel and conveying it exactly — is expressly declared an "error". In the Qur'an the Prophet is not a founder but a **conveyor**; and being unlettered is not a deficiency but evidence that the revelation is independent of any human accumulation. *Two necessary notes:* (a) the characterisation rejected in [Quote-24](#) is composite — the books add to the list caricatural elements ("an illiterate, ignorant, unfeeling and motionless idol") that no Islamic source has ever claimed, and the direct target of the rejection is that caricature of passivity. (b) Even so, the part "who takes everything from an angel and conveys it exactly" does correspond to the definition of messengership, and [Quote-22](#) closes off any mitigating reading.

The same pattern is applied to Moses

[Quote-25] "Musa gençliğinde uzun müddet Medyen de bulunmuş ve buradaki telâkkilerden mülhem olarak kendi dininin esaslarını koymuştur." — **Tarih II, p. 80** [In his youth Moses stayed a long time in Midian and, inspired by the conceptions there, laid down the principles of his own religion.]

[Verse-14] "I have chosen you, so listen to what is revealed. Indeed, I am God; there is no god but I, so worship Me." — **Ṭā Hā 13-14**

[Finding-12] The same explanatory pattern is applied to Moses: inspired by the conceptions of Midian, he laid down the principles of his religion himself. The verdict is thus extended not to a single prophet but to the institution of prophethood as a whole. In the Qur'an Moses does not found his religion; he is chosen, and revelation is given to him.

3.4 The origin of belief in jinn and angels

Belief in jinn is tied to Arab soothsaying culture

[Quote-26] "Bu kuvvetler Araplar için cinlerdi. Cinler, **gûya**, kâhinlere kayıptan haber vermek kudretini ilham ederlerdi. Bu nevi itikatlar Arabistanda her zaman o kadar canlı ve derin olmuştur ki Muhammet **dahi** cinlerin vücuduna samimî olarak inanmıştır." — **Tarih II, p. 91** [For the Arabs these powers were the jinn. The jinn, supposedly, inspired soothsayers with the power to give news of the unseen. Beliefs of this kind have always been so vivid and deep in Arabia that Muhammad too sincerely believed in the existence of the jinn.]

[Verse-15] "And He created the jinn from a smokeless flame of fire." — **Ar-Raḥmān 15**

[Verse-16] "Say: It has been revealed to me that a company of the jinn listened and said: 'We have heard a wondrous Qur'an that guides to rectitude, and we have believed in it.'" — **Al-Jinn 1-2**

[Finding-13] Belief in jinn is tied to the soothsaying culture of Arabia, and it is written that the Prophet acquired that belief from his surroundings. In the Qur'an the jinn are a species God created, and the source of knowledge about them is not culture but revelation. The two accounts of origin cannot be reconciled. *Three words take the passage out of the descriptive:* "**gûya**" ("supposedly" — the books do not treat the act as real), "**dahi**" ("too" — a belief one would not expect him to share), and "**kuvvetlendirmiştir**" ("strengthened it" — the belief was acquired later).

The source of the conception of angels is tied to earlier religions

[Quote-27] "Muhammedin Musa, İsa, dinlerine dair öğrendikleri de kendisinde bu itikadı **kuvvetlendirmiştir**. Bu Peygamberler de melekler vasıtasile ilham aldıklarını söylemişlerdi. O dinlerde de cin ve melek telâkkisi vardı." — **Tarih II, p. 91** [What Muhammad learned about the religions of Moses and Jesus also strengthened this belief in him. Those prophets too had said that they received inspiration through angels. In those religions as well there was a conception of jinn and angels.]

[Quote-28] "**Dinler nazarında** cinler, kötü ruhlar olduğundan peygamberler onlardan mülhem olamazlardı."

— **Tarih II, p. 91** [In the view of the religions, since the jinn are evil spirits, prophets could not have been inspired by them.]

[**Verse-17**] "The Messenger believes in what has been sent down to him from his Lord, and so do the believers. Each one believes in God, His angels, His books and His messengers." — **Al-Baqara 285**

[**Finding-14**] The source of belief in angels is tied to what was learned from earlier religions; the belief is presented not as a truth conveyed by revelation but as a conviction reinforced through cultural contact. In the Qur'an belief in the angels is one of the enumerated articles of faith. *A necessary note.* In **Quote-28** the books do not deliver the verdict in their own voice; they refer it to the religions with the qualification "in the view of the religions". This is the same construction as "in Islamic tradition ... it is accepted" in **Quote-19**: the verdict is referred elsewhere, and the books do not affirm it.

3.5 Scripture, law and sacred place

The Kaaba narrative is declared "fabricated tales"

[**Quote-29**] "Bu uydurmalarla göre İbrahim, karısı Hacer ile oğlu İsmaili buraya getirmişti; Zemzem de onlar için fışkırmıştı; İbrahim, oğlu İsmail ile birlikte Kâbeyi bina etmişlerdi. ... Bunların hepsi, **bittabi, soradan uydurulmuş masallardır.**" — **Tarih II, p. 85** [According to these fabrications Abraham had brought his wife Hagar and his son Ishmael here; Zamzam had gushed forth for them; Abraham together with his son Ishmael had built the Kaaba. ... All of these are, of course, tales fabricated later.]

[**Verse-18**] "As Abraham raised the foundations of the House, together with Ishmael: 'Our Lord, accept this from us. You are indeed the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.'" — **Al-Baqara 127**

[**Finding-15**] That the Kaaba was built by Abraham and Ishmael is declared a set of "tales fabricated later". Yet this is an explicit statement of the Qur'an. To count as a tale a report established by definitive scripture is a direct conflict with scripture.

The origin of sanctity is tied to a human and political ground

[**Quote-30**] "Demek ki Kâbenin bir köşesindeki Karataşın kutsiyet almasından, ziyaret ve tavaf edilmesinden çok evvel Friklerde karataşın mabet ve ziyaretgâh esası olması âdeti teessüs eylemiş bulunuyordu." — **Tarih II, p. 85** [So then, long before the Black Stone in a corner of the Kaaba acquired sanctity and came to be visited and circumambulated, the custom of the black stone as the basis of a temple and a place of visitation had already been established among the Phrygians.]

[**Quote-31**] "...muharebelerin men'i maksadile birtakım kaideler konmuştu. Bunların herbirine **dinî şekiller verilmişti.**" — **Tarih II, p. 85-86** [with the aim of preventing wars a number of rules were laid down. Each of these had been given religious forms.]

[**Verse-19**] "The first House established for mankind was the one at Mecca — blessed, and a guidance for all peoples." — **Âl 'Imrân 96**

[**Finding-16**] The sanctity of the Kaaba is tied to the Phrygian custom of the black stone, and religious forms to the aim of preventing wars: sanctity is derived not from revelation but from earlier customs and political need. In the Qur'an it is God who made the House the first house established for mankind.

The permanence of the law is removed by implication

[**Quote-32**] "...on dört asır evvelki zaman ve mekânın ihtiyacına göre lüzumlu ve kâfi görülmüş olan esaslar yerine bugün birçok mütenevvi kanunlar ve usuller konulmak zarureti görülmüştür. Bunlar **dahi ebedî olmayıp zamanla değişmeğe mahkûmdurlar.**" — **Tarih II, p. 92** [in place of the principles deemed necessary and sufficient for the needs of the time and place fourteen centuries ago, it has been found necessary today to lay down many and varied laws and procedures. These too are not eternal and are condemned to change with time.]

[**Verse-20**] "Any revelation We cause to be abrogated or forgotten, We replace with something better or similar." — **Al-Baqara 106**

[Finding-17] The verdict is given that the rules are "not eternal and are condemned to change with time". Literally, "these" are the newly enacted laws; the extension to Qur'anic rulings follows from the implication of the word "dahi" ("too") — a strong implication, but not an explicit statement. In the Qur'an the authority to abrogate belongs to God; a ruling changes only by revelation.

4. Where the books praise Muhammad, and what that praise is worth doctrinally

This part is required by the honesty of the report. But **the sentences of praise are not a doctrinal acceptance**; the reason is set out in [section 4.2](#).

4.1 The sentences of praise

[Quote-33] "Muhammet namuskâr ve menfaat fikrinden ari olarak ortaya atıldı. Onun gayesi, muhitinin ahlâkını, dinini ve içtimâî hayatını ıslah etmektir." — **Tarih II, p. 91** [Muhammad came forward as an honest man free from any thought of gain. His aim was to reform the morals, the religion and the social life of his environment.]

[Quote-34] "Muhammet denilen şahsiyet bizatihi mütehassis, mütefekkir, müteşebbis ve **muasırlarının en yükseği** olduğunu yaptığı işlerle ispat etmiş bir varlıktı." — **Tarih II, p. 93** [The personality called Muhammad was a being who proved by the works he accomplished that he was in himself sensitive, thoughtful, enterprising and the highest of his contemporaries.]

[Verse-21] "Say: I am only a human being like you; it is revealed to me that your God is One God." — **Al-Kahf 110**

[Finding-18] The praise remains wholly within human categories: Muhammad is described as a moral and social reformer, a man of superior qualities and a historical personality; and his superiority is counted as something he **"proved by the works he accomplished"**. None of the qualities praised belongs to prophethood — the merits are attributed to the person himself, to his own effort and to his works. In the Qur'an what distinguishes the Prophet is not his personal merits but that **revelation is given to him**; being human and being a messenger are stated together in the same verse.

4.2 Praise does not soften the doctrinal conflict

The books deliver a positive verdict on the Prophet's morals and do not say that he "deceived". But from this it does not follow that "the books accept Islam" or that "the doctrinal conflict softens". The reason is definite.

There is no vague "feeling of inspiration" here; there is the claim of a specific external event. The claim is this: the verses of the Qur'an were sent down **by God through an angel named Gabriel**. This is not a subjective feeling but an event reported to have occurred outside the mind. The books know it, because they record it themselves: they relay the claim as it stands, but with the qualification "in Islamic tradition ... it is accepted" (**Quote-19**).

Immediately afterwards they place their own verdict: the idea of revelation was born in the Prophet after years of reflection (**Quote-20**); the verses are the product of the reflections of a long period (**Quote-22**). That is, the books do not **read** the same experience differently; they say the reported event **did not occur**. In place of an external conveyance through an angel they put an idea that arises in the mind and ripens over time.

A specific external event either occurred or it did not. The books say it did not: not an external conveyance through an angel, but an idea arising in the mind. On that account, whatever is said about the Prophet's morals, the report "Gabriel brought it from God" is held **not to have taken place**, and the Qur'an ceases to be the word of God. The verdict on morals changes; **the verdict on the source of the Qur'an does not**.

The Qur'an frames its own question with two alternatives and admits no third. The question is not about the morals of the speaker but about the origin of the word:

[Verse-22] "Or do they say, 'He has invented it'? No — they simply do not believe. Then let them produce a discourse like it, if they are truthful." — **Aṭ-Ṭūr 33-34**

The same dilemma and the same challenge (*taḥaddī*) are repeated: Al-Baqara 23; Yūnus 37-38; Hūd 13; Al-Isrā' 88. The Qur'an closes off the possibility of invention not with a **third alternative** but with a **test**. Further, it states the consequence of the assumption of invention itself: *"If he had invented sayings and attributed them to Us, We would have seized him by the right hand and cut his lifeline"* (Al-Hāqqa 44-46). Within the Qur'an's own frame the possibilities are two: **either it is from God, or it is a fabrication.**

Nor is there a third category in doctrine. In prophethood *ṣidq* is not the subjective sincerity of the agent but **the truth of what is conveyed**. The prophets are protected by *ʿiṣma* from error in conveyance; to say "he took it for revelation but it came from his own reflection" invalidates that protection and the claim to messengership together.

[Finding-19] The books say that revelation arose from the Prophet's own reflection; the report "Gabriel brought it from God" is thereby held not to have occurred. Whatever is said about the Prophet's morals, the verdict on the source of the Qur'an does not change: the Qur'an has been removed from being the word of God. The quotations it rests on are in [section 3.3](#); this section discusses their doctrinal consequence.

5. What can be said on the basis of the books

The following is the plain wording of the books; it requires no inference.

1. The books count religion an institution founded by human beings "like the other social institutions". ([Quote-04](#))
2. They write that what "found" the concept of divinity was human intelligence. ([Quote-05](#))
3. They define "the initial form of the concept of God" as the "exalted ancestor". ([Quote-01](#))
4. They state that primitive man had no idea whatever of God or religion. ([Quote-09](#))
5. They count every concept above nature a "fabrication" as far as the human mind is concerned. ([Quote-08](#))
6. They teach that "it must be accepted" that life came about without any agent outside nature. ([Quote-11](#))
7. They count man "a creature of nature" and write that he reached his present form by evolution. ([Quote-13](#), [Quote-15](#))
8. They set out the chain of life and place man at its end: "monkeys, apes, and finally human beings". ([Quote-16](#))
9. They say that "one arrives at the conviction" that man descends "from ancestors belonging to a simpler class". ([Quote-17](#))
10. They define the Qur'an as "the book in which the principles laid down by Muhammad are gathered". ([Quote-19](#))
11. They do not affirm the divine source of the verses in their own voice; they refer it to tradition with "in Islamic tradition ... it is accepted". ([Quote-19](#))
12. They give their own verdict under the qualification "from the historical point of view" and present revelation as an idea arising in the Prophet's mind: "the idea of revelation and inspiration was born in him". ([Quote-20](#))
13. They characterise Islam as a "new religion which he had found himself". ([Quote-21](#))
14. They count the verses "the product of the reflections of a long period" — the same claim as the characterisation "the word of a human being" which the Qur'an rejects by name. ([Quote-22](#))

15. They present prophethood as a gradual transition and count Muhammad the "founder" of the religion. ([Quote-23](#))
 16. They characterise as an "error" the conception of a prophet who receives revelation from an angel and conveys it exactly. ([Quote-24](#))
 17. They apply the same "he laid down the principles of his own religion" model to Moses. ([Quote-25](#))
 18. They declare the set that includes Abraham and Ishmael's building of the Kaaba to be "fabricated tales". ([Quote-29](#))
 19. They count legal rulings "condemned to change" without distinguishing what is fixed by scripture from what is the product of juristic reasoning. ([Quote-32](#))
 20. They tie belief in jinn to Arab soothsaying culture, write that the Prophet acquired this belief and "strengthened" it with what he learned from neighbouring religions, and relay the jinn's inspiration of soothsayers with the qualification "supposedly". ([Quote-26](#))
 21. They tie the source of the conception of angels to earlier religions as well: "in those religions as well there was a conception of jinn and angels". ([Quote-27](#))
 22. They do not deliver the verdict "prophets could not have been inspired by jinn" in their own voice; they refer it to the religions with "in the view of the religions". ([Quote-28](#))
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6. Conclusion

This review has compared what *Tarih I* and *Tarih II* say about religion and Islam with the articles of belief as the Qur'an sets them out. Across five axes, thirty-four quotations were assessed against the twenty-two verses on which they bear, yielding nineteen findings. **The findings point not to scattered remarks but to a single framework: the books count religion an institution founded by human beings, divinity a concept found by human intelligence, revelation the product of the Prophet's reflection, and the unseen a human attribution.** The divergence between this framework and what the Qur'an states is not one of detail but of principle; nor does the praise directed at the Prophet's morals remove it, since that praise remains wholly within human categories. This framework was taught in the lycées for eleven years not as a private author's opinion but as **the state's official teaching.**

7. Source and verification

All quotations are taken verbatim from text that was corrected by hand, page by page, against the scanned originals. That text is publicly available:

- **Beşer Tarihi** — *Tarih I*, pp. 1-24: [corrected full text](#)
- **İslâm Tarihi** — *Tarih II*, pp. 79-184: [corrected full text](#)

The page-by-page view, with a link from each page to its scanned original, is in the [index of corrected sections](#); the full scans of the volumes are references [1] and [2].

The text examined is the **1931 first printing**; the scan of the 1941 printing is recorded in the TTK catalogue but is not available online. The text was corrected by hand; the raw OCR output is kept alongside each record, so every correction can be audited.

Basis of the sources. The doctrinal grounds of this report are **the verses of the Qur'an alone**. No modern author's commentary and no work belonging to a school or movement has been relied upon; the aim is to keep the report's basis as broad as possible. The quotations from the 1931 printing are in the public domain, and the report's own text is released under CC0, so the whole document may be freely reproduced.

The spelling in the quotations is that of the 1931 printing and has not been corrected: *sora*, *evel*, *tabiat*, *iptidaî*, *mabut*, *neş'et*.

In an earlier version of this report the forms *her şeyi*, *sahsiyet* and *Karataşm* were left as they stood, taken to be typesetting errors of the printing. They were checked against the scan: all three come from the OCR, not from the printing; the printed page reads *her şeyi* (p. 93), *şahsiyet* (p. 93) and *Karataşın* (p. 85). The quotations have been corrected to match the printing.

Quotation marks inside a quotation have been rendered as single quotes (the printing has "*kabile allahı*", the report '*kabile allahı*'); apart from this the wording has not been altered. All 34 verbatim quotations in the report are present letter for letter in the corrected text of the page named in their citation, and this is machine-verified.

8. Bibliography

Scanned originals — Turkish Historical Society Library, call no. A/4789.

- [1] *Tarih I*, Turkish History Research Society, Ministry of Education, State Press, Istanbul 1931.
[Library record](#)
- [2] *Tarih II*, Turkish History Research Society, Ministry of Education, State Press, Istanbul 1931.
[Library record](#)

Colophon pages — the source of the printing order and the number of copies.

- [3] [Tarih I, colophon](#)
- [4] [Tarih II, colophon](#)

Decisions of the Board of Education.

- [5] [Index of 1931 decisions](#)
- [6] [Index of 1932 decisions](#)
- [7] [Index of 1941 decisions](#)
- [8] [Index of 1942 decisions](#)

Library records.

- [9] [TTK Library, AKM/K/16799 — "2nd edition", Ministry of Education, 1933](#)
- [10] [TTK Library, Ortamektep için Tarih, Ministry of Education, 1933](#)
- [11] [TTK Library, AKM/K/10726 — "3rd printing", Ministry of Education, 1932-1941](#). The number of copies of the 1941 printing of *Tarih II* is on that printing's colophon; the scan of that page is not online.

Archive.

- [12] [Board of Education, archive of decision indexes](#) — all indexes from 1927 to 1942 were searched.

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